

Shaoxuanzi Sheng

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Authoritarian institutions; Chinese politics; state building; bureaucracy; state-society relations.

EDUCATION

- Duke University** August 2025 – Present
M.A. in Political Science; GPA: 3.95/4.00
◦ Master's thesis: *State Presence as State Building* (in progress). Durham, NC, USA
- Communication University of China** September 2021 – June 2025
LL.B. in Political Science and Administration; GPA: 3.87/4.00 Beijing, China
◦ Thesis: *From Face-to-Face to Smart: How Digital Government Reshapes Public Perceptions of Government Responsiveness.*
- University of Notre Dame** August 2023 – December 2023
Exchange Program, Department of Political Science; GPA: 3.75/4.00 South Bend, IN, USA
- Peking University–The University of Chicago International Policy Action Lab** July 2023 – August 2023
Summer School Beijing, China
◦ Coursework: Applied Econometrics; Programming in Stata; Public Policy Capstone Project.

WORKING PAPERS

- [WP.1] **“Crisis-Driven Institution Building: Evidence from COVID-19.”** With Xiongfeng Xiao.
Under review. Available at SSRN.
Develops a sequential theory of crisis-driven institution building in which crisis pressure generates emergency institutions that subsequently sediment into routinized governance. The empirical analysis uses a country-week panel of COVID-19 responses from 2020 to 2022, fixed effects, and a leave-one-out exposure instrumental-variable design based on pre-pandemic mobility networks.
- [WP.2] **“Administrative Reform as Institutional Purge: Evidence from Vietnam.”** With Xiongfeng Xiao and Qingwen Deng.
Under review. SSRN link forthcoming.
Develops a theory of institutional purge in authoritarian administrative reform. Using Vietnam's 2025 province-level consolidation, the project combines a formal model with an original dataset linking province-level institutional survival, central elite profiles, and local elite career networks.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

- [W.1] **“Beyond Payoff Maximization: Authoritarian Resilience and Policy Experimentation in China.”** Work in progress.
Develops a risk-management account of policy experimentation in authoritarian regimes. The project constructs an original subnational measure of regional resilience and examines how structural, institutional, and social capacities shape pilot selection and post-reform outcomes in China.
- [W.2] ***State Presence as State Building.*** Master's thesis in progress, Duke University.
Examines how state presence contributes to state building in contemporary China, with attention to the relationship between bureaucratic presence, institutional control, and state capacity.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- [C.1] Sheng, Shaoxuanzi. 2024. “Where Is Our Future”: Political Attitudes Under the Impact of Narrative Expression in Science Fiction Films. Paper accepted for presentation at the 53rd Annual Meeting of the SouthWest Conference on Asian Studies.

HONORS AND AWARDS

- Dean's Research Award for Master's Students** 2025–2026
The Graduate School, Duke University Durham, NC
- Bronze Medal** 2024
“Challenge Cup” Beijing Research and Entrepreneurship Competition Beijing, China
- Special Award for Research Reports** 2023
School of Government and Public Affairs, Communication University of China Beijing, China

ACADEMIC SERVICE AND LEADERSHIP

- Student Group Leader** May 2023 – September 2024
Editor Team, Studies of Chinese Political Communication Beijing, China
- Founder and President** August 2022 – September 2023
CUC Model Chinese People's Political Consultative Conference Club Beijing, China
- Member, Secretary Team and Promotion Team** May 2023
The Fifth China's Political Communication Studies Academic Forum Beijing, China
- Youth Representative** May 2023
The 2023 Chinese Young Politician Forum Beijing, China

SKILLS

- Research Methods:** formal modeling, causal inference, social network analysis, text as data, survey experiment.
- Software and Programming:** R, Python, Stata, LaTeX, Microsoft Office Suite.
- Languages:** Mandarin Chinese (native); English (proficient).